

COMPREHENSIVE DELHI HERITAGE & MONUMENTS REFERENCE GUIDE (EXPANDED EDITION)

DEL001: Red Fort (Lal Qila)

Commissioned by Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan in 1639 when he decided to shift his imperial capital from Agra to Shahjahanabad (Delhi). Designed by the master architect Ustad Ahmad Lahori, the fort is constructed primarily of red sandstone, giving it its iconic name. It served as the main residence of the Mughal emperors for nearly 200 years and is a UNESCO World Heritage site. The monument experiences severe tourist pressure, particularly around the Diwan-i-Aam (Hall of Public Audience) and the Lahori Gate entrance.

DEL002: Qutub Minar

A towering 73-meter victory tower and minaret located in Mehrauli. Construction was initiated by Qutb-ud-din Aibak, the founder of the Delhi Sultanate, in 1192, and was later completed by his successor, Iltutmish. The minaret is constructed from red sandstone and marble, decorated with intricate Arabic inscriptions. Due to structural aging, previous earthquake damage, and the delicate nature of the ancient stone carvings, public entry inside the tower is strictly prohibited to safeguard its structural integrity.

DEL003: Humayun's Tomb

Commissioned by Humayun's first wife and chief consort, Empress Bega Begum, in 1558, and designed by the Persian architect Mirak Mirza Ghiyas. Completed in 1572, it is the very first garden-tomb on the Indian subcontinent and served as a direct architectural precursor to the Taj Mahal. The complex features an expansive Charbagh (four-quadrant symmetrical garden layout divided by water channels), which naturally helps dissipate large visitor crowds and lowers heritage pressure on the central mausoleum.

DEL004: India Gate

Originally named the All India War Memorial, India Gate is a monumental war memorial designed by the prominent British architect Sir Edwin Lutyens. It was unveiled in 1931 to commemorate the 70,000 soldiers of the British Indian Army who lost their lives during the First World War and the Third Anglo-Afghan War. Because it stands as an open-air public urban landmark without enclosed structural chambers, its capacity is virtually unlimited, and heritage pressure remains low even during peak weekends.

DEL005: Lotus Temple

Completed in December 1986, the Lotus Temple is a Bahá'í House of Worship renowned for its striking flowerlike architectural shape. Designed by the Iranian-American architect Fariborz Sahba, the structure is composed of 27 free-standing marble-clad "petals" arranged in clusters of three to form nine doors opening into a central hall. The management enforces strict silence inside the prayer hall and utilizes structured queue systems to handle massive daily footfall efficiently.

DEL006: Akshardham Temple

A massive spiritual and cultural campus opened in November 2005, showcasing millennia of traditional Hindu culture, spirituality, and architecture. The main monument is built entirely from pink sandstone and Italian Carrara marble without the use of any ferrous metals or steel girders. It features extensive exhibition halls, open gardens, and a large musical water

fountain, attracting high visitor volumes managed through strict security and ticketing protocols.

DEL007: Jama Masjid

Commissioned by Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan between 1644 and 1656 (completed in 1656), Jama Masjid is one of the largest and most renowned mosques in India. Built using alternating strips of red sandstone and white marble, it features three grand entrance gates, four towering minarets, and a vast central courtyard capable of holding thousands of worshippers. Its location in the dense urban fabric of Old Delhi creates heavy pedestrian and tourist congestion.

DEL008: Jantar Mantar

An astronomical observatory constructed by the Rajput King Maharaja Jai Singh II of Jaipur in 1724. It consists of 13 distinct architectural astronomy instruments designed to compile astronomical tables and predict the movements of the sun, moon, and planets with remarkable precision for the 18th century. Being an open-air stone instrument park, it experiences moderate, manageable visitor pressure.

DEL009: Lodhi Garden

A sprawling 90-acre city park in New Delhi that contains protected architectural heritage structures from the Sayyid and Lodhi dynasty eras, including the magnificent tombs of Mohammed Shah and Sikandar Lodi, alongside historic bridges and landscaped lawns. It acts as a popular public recreational space, maintaining low structural heritage pressure due to its wide open green footprint.

DEL010: Chandni Chowk

Established in the 17th century by Shah Jahan and designed by his daughter Jahanara, Chandni Chowk is one of the oldest and busiest commercial markets in Old Delhi. Famous for its labyrinthine alleys, traditional street food vendors, wholesale spice and textile bazaars, and historic merchant havelis, it represents a vibrant living heritage zone with high foot traffic intensity.

DEL011: Rashtrapati Bhavan (Exterior)

The official residence of the President of India, originally built as the Viceroy's House and designed by architects Sir Edwin Lutyens and Herbert Baker. Completed in 1929, the grand structure seamlessly blends classical European architectural forms (such as neo-classical columns and a massive dome inspired by the Pantheon) with indigenous Indian motifs and stone lattices.

DEL012: Raj Ghat

A serene memorial dedicated to Mahatma Gandhi, marking the exact spot of his cremation following his assassination on January 30, 1948. The memorial consists of a simple square platform of black marble set amidst manicured lawns and walled gardens, where an eternal flame burns continuously.

DEL013: Purana Qila (Old Fort)

One of the oldest historic forts in Delhi, standing on an ancient mound whose layers date back over 2,500 years to the legendary epic city of Indraprastha. The current massive

fortifications and gateways were constructed by the Afghan ruler Sher Shah Suri and later modified by Humayun. It features thick stone walls, grand arched entry gates, and a surrounding moat.

DEL014: Safdarjung Tomb

A grand garden mausoleum built in 1754 during the late Mughal period. It was constructed as the final resting place for Mirza Muqim Abul Mansur Khan, popularly known as Safdarjung, who served as the Prime Minister (Vizier) of the Mughal Empire. Built using red sandstone and buff stone panels with an impressive central marble dome, it reflects the architectural transition before the decline of Mughal power.

DEL015: National Museum

Established in 1949, the National Museum in New Delhi houses a massive collection of over 200,000 works of art and historical artifacts spanning more than 5,000 years of Indian civilization. Its galleries display rare Harappan Dancing Girl sculptures, Mauryan terracottas, ancient manuscripts, temple bronzes, and royal miniature paintings in a controlled indoor environment.

DEL016: Agrasen ki Baoli

A historic 60-meter long and 15-meter wide stepwell (baoli) situated on Hailey Road. Consisting of three distinct levels of receding stone steps lined with arched niches, it stands as an exceptional surviving example of medieval water-conservation architecture designed to withstand summer heat and sustain water supplies in central Delhi.

DEL017: Hauz Khas Village & Fort

An upscale urban district built around a massive historic water reservoir (tank) originally commissioned by Sultan Alauddin Khalji in the 13th century. The adjacent medieval complex includes the ruler's madrasa, tomb structures, and domed pavilions, juxtaposed with contemporary art galleries, boutiques, and cafes.

DEL018: ISKCON Temple

A prominent Vaishnavite spiritual complex built in 1998 on Hare Krishna Hill. The temple is famous for its intricate shikhara architecture, multimedia robotic exhibitions explaining the Bhagavad Gita, and vibrant cultural displays attracting devotees and tourists alike.

DEL019: Gurudwara Bangla Sahib

One of the most prominent and spiritually significant Sikh gurdwaras in Delhi, originally a bungalow belonging to Raja Jai Singh. It is universally celebrated for its association with the eighth Sikh Guru, Guru Har Krishan. The complex features a sacred healing pool (sarovar) and one of the largest community kitchens (langar) serving free meals daily.

DEL020: Dilli Haat

A permanent open-air craft bazaar and ethnic food plaza managed by Delhi Tourism, created to simulate a traditional weekly village marketplace (haat). It provides a controlled platform for rural artisans, weavers, and craftspeople from across India to exhibit and sell authentic handlooms and regional handicrafts without middlemen.

DEL021: Mehrauli Archaeological Park

Spread across over 200 acres adjacent to the Qutub Minar complex, this archaeological site contains over 100 historically significant monuments spanning a thousand years of Delhi's history. Notable structures include the ornate tomb of Ghiyasuddin Balban, the Jamali Kamali Mosque and Tomb, and historic stepwells tucked within forested trails.

DEL022: National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA)

Located inside the historic Jaipur House—the former residence of the Maharaja of Jaipur—the NGMA houses India's premier collection of modern and contemporary visual art. Its permanent collections trace the evolution of Indian art from the British colonial period in the 1850s through the Bengal School to modern abstractionists.

DEL023: Indira Gandhi Memorial Museum

The former official residence of India's first female Prime Minister, Indira Gandhi, located at 1 Safdarjung Road. Following her assassination in 1984, the residence was converted into a public museum preserving the rooms where she lived and worked, alongside photographic archives and personal memorabilia.

DEL024: Nehru Planetarium

Situated within the historic Teen Murti House estate (once the residence of India's first Prime Minister, Jawaharlal Nehru), the planetarium is dedicated to popularizing astronomy and space science through educational sky-theatre shows, exhibits, and public stargazing events.

DEL025: National Crafts Museum

A specialized cultural museum showcasing traditional Indian folk arts, tribal crafts, and rural village architecture. The campus includes open-air courtyards where master craftspeople from across the country demonstrate traditional textile weaving, pottery, block printing, and wood carving live.

DEL026: Tughlaqabad Fort

Constructed in 1321 by Ghiyas-ud-din Tughlaq, the founder of the Tughlaq dynasty, as his capital city. Built across a rugged rocky terrain, it is famous for its massive sloping stone ramparts, intimidating defensive bastions, and sprawling ruined royal palaces reflecting stern military architecture.

DEL027: Waste to Wonder Park

An innovative thematic public park featuring scale replicas of the Seven Wonders of the World constructed entirely from industrial scrap metal, discarded automobile parts, old iron pipes, and municipal waste, highlighting creative urban recycling and environmental awareness.

DEL028: Garden of Five Senses

A 20-acre leisure park designed to stimulate human sensory perceptions through environmental design. It features distinct thematic zones containing flowering shrubs, cascading water elements, contemporary public art sculptures, rock formations, and food pavilions.

DEL029: Sulabh International Museum of Toilets

A unique and quirky museum established by the Sulabh Sanitation Movement to document the global history of sanitation, toilet design, hygiene habits, and social evolution across different civilizations from 2500 BCE to modern times.

DEL030: Chattarpur Temple

A sprawling temple complex dedicated to Goddess Katyayani, established in 1974. It covers a vast expanse featuring a unique fusion of North and South Indian architectural styles across large white marble prayer halls, beautifully landscaped courtyards, and silver shrines.